

Tethering can be a little messy and does not allow you to move your phone. It can be unstable depending on software installed in either your phone or your PC. Wi-Fi hotspots do not cause as much trouble.



Wi-Fi dongles also enable you to connect to your home network if your router is too far from your PC

Most dongles have USB 2.0 and above support and are good to go with the hardware but can be troublesome with the software. Windows as well as Linux can automatically detect most Wi-Fi devices; however, some cannot be used without installing the driver first (e.g. D-Link DWA 131). Linux becomes a trouble because driver installations are not easy on Linux. This can be a problem if you are unable to locate the driver disk and you cannot locate one online either.

You may also want to go for the latest standards – while still not widely in use, 802.11 ac is catching up. There are dongles which support the ac standard – they come at a higher price and you might not need them if your access point does not. We recommend you to go for an adapter that at least supports 802.11 n standard.

Bluetooth dongle / adapter

Bluetooth, though slower than Wi-Fi is more useful in some ways. Certain capabilities of Bluetooth are:

1. It allows you to transfer files to the system.
2. Audio playback on Bluetooth enabled headsets and speaker systems.
3. Connect to Bluetooth enabled wireless keyboard and mouse.
4. Connect to your phone's Bluetooth PAN (Personal Area Network) to share the internet connection.
5. A printer that can use Bluetooth can be used without much hassle.

While there are devices which can get all this done over Wi-Fi, they are more expensive.

Some adapters might need driver software. If it needs the driver and won't function without it, try avoiding them. We have known Bluetooth adapter drivers to corrupt networking drivers, audio playback drivers and more. At the same time, many drivers get installed without a hint of a trouble. Some adapters just do not need any driver software – true plug and play – how Bluetooth is supposed to be in this age.